

practical. If there are already too many complaints, pick a subset on which you want to focus. Make sure that the rule that determines which kinds of complaints trigger a Five Whys meeting is simple and ironclad. For example, you might decide that every complaint involving a credit card transaction will be investigated. That's an easy rule to follow. Don't pick a rule that is ambiguous.

At first, the temptation may be to make radical and deep changes to every billing system and process. Don't. Instead, keep the meetings short and pick relatively simple changes at each of the five levels of the inquiry. Over time, as the team gets more comfortable with the process, you can expand it to include more and more types of billing complaints and then to other kinds of problems.

Appoint a Five Whys Master

To facilitate learning, I have found it helpful to appoint a Five Whys master for each area in which the method is being used. This individual is tasked with being the moderator for each Five Whys meeting, making decisions about which prevention steps to take, and assigning the follow-up work from that meeting. The master must be senior enough to have the authority to ensure that those assignments get done but should not be so senior that he or she will not be able to be present at the meetings because of conflicting responsibilities. The Five Whys master is the point person in terms of accountability; he or she is the primary change agent. People in this position can assess how well the meetings are going and whether the prevention investments that are being made are paying off.

THE FIVE WHYS IN ACTION

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